SWARM ALIGNMENT HACKATHON · NOVEMBER 2026

Lock before you talk

Pooling first reads beats deliberation when LLM panels split the evidence

Vaughn DiMarco · Uptick Systems

8,082 logged calls · 6 model families · 30 cases with known answers

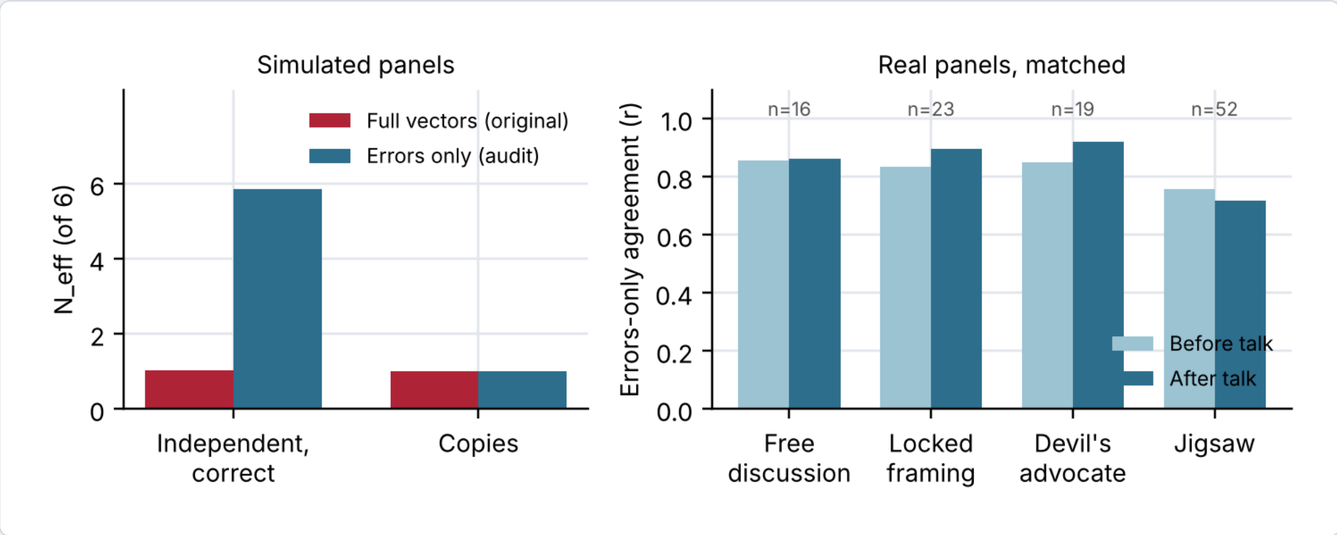
THE QUESTION

Should a panel of AI agents talk before it decides?

- Panels of six models from six families solve fictional whodunit cases. Every case has one known culprit.
- Each agent gives a first read alone. Then the panel talks for two rounds, and each agent gives a final read.
- We compare two decisions on the same panels: the average of the locked first reads, and the average after talk.
- In the jigsaw arm, each clue goes to only 3 of the 6 agents.

AN AUDIT OF OUR OWN FIRST DRAFT

The usual agreement measure counts correct agents as one voice



1.02 of 6

independent, correct agents on the old measure

5.86 of 6

the same agents, errors only

FINDING 1

Panels share their errors before they talk

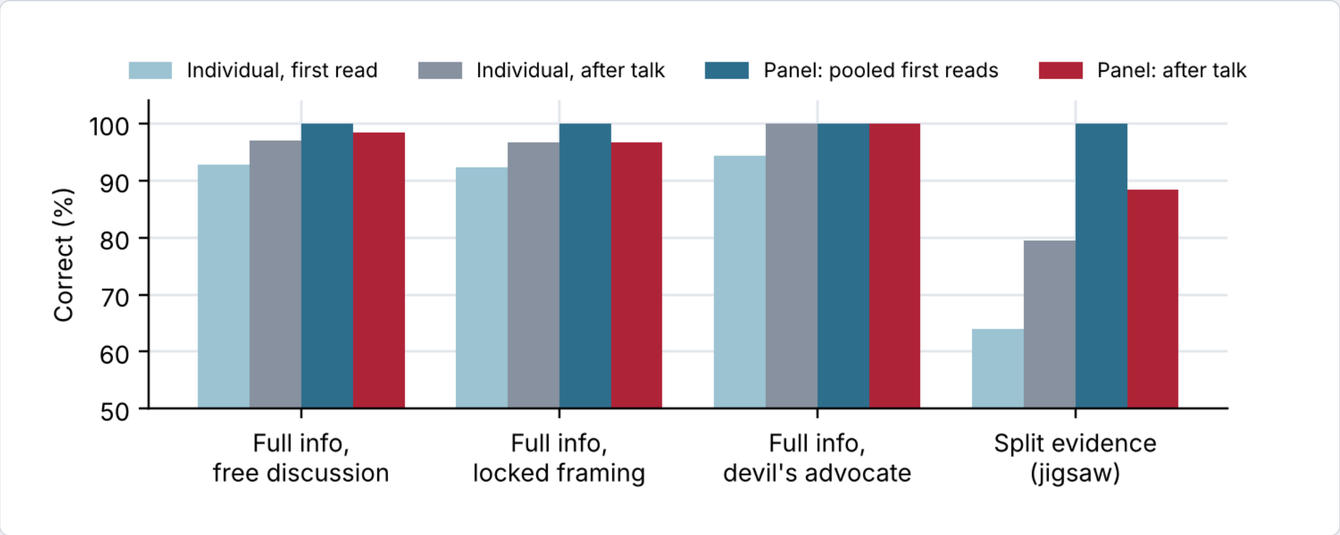
0.857 → 0.863

errors-only agreement, before and after free discussion

Our first draft called discussion a collapse to one voice. On the corrected measure, free discussion barely changes agreement. We retract the collapse claim.

FINDING 2

With split evidence, pooling first reads beats talk



60 of 60

pooled locked first reads

53 of 60

vote after discussion (p = 0.016; by case, p = 0.06)

WHY

Talk helps each agent, and hurts the panel

- Individual accuracy rose from 64% to 80% after talk.
- But the average of private reads already held all the evidence. Discussion pulled some panels toward a story that fit the shared clues.
- In 3 failed adversarial cases, the discussed vote chose the planted decoy every time.
- This is the hidden-profile effect seen in human groups (Stasser and Titus, 1985).

RETRACTIONS

What our first draft got wrong

- **Deliberation collapse:** retracted. It was a measurement artifact.
- **Same-model premium of +0.082:** retracted. Qwen copies answered with 100% certainty, so the test measured certainty.
- **Locked first reads fail:** revised. Telling agents their read is locked does nothing, but using locked reads as the vote never lost a decision.
- All 11,402 logged calls are now public, so anyone can check this.

TAKEAWAY

Record each agent's read before it talks, and pool those reads

- Measure agent independence on errors, not on answers.
- When monitors see different evidence, discussion can lose what a simple average keeps.
- Locking and pooling first reads costs almost nothing.

github.com/vdimarco/apart-swarm-alignment